

York & the Minster - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

From Eboracum to York: A Capital in Layers

York's claim to be England's second city historically rests on an extraordinary run: Roman legionary fortress and provincial capital, seat of two imperial courts, Anglo-Saxon royal and ecclesiastical center, Viking capital, and the medieval North's metropolis. Eboracum was founded in 71 AD by the Ninth Legion; the emperor Septimius Severus ruled the entire Roman Empire from here for three years while campaigning in Scotland, and died here in 211 — as did Constantius Chlorus in 306, whereupon the army acclaimed his son Constantine as emperor in York, an event with reasonable claim to be the most consequential thing that ever happened in northern England, given where Constantine took Christianity. Roman masonry still surfaces everywhere: the Multangular Tower in the Museum Gardens stands to height, and a Roman column re-erected opposite the Minster came from the fortress headquarters — which lies directly beneath the Minster itself; the Undercroft museum takes you down through the strata. The city walls, though medieval in their present form, largely ride on the Roman rampart line — at three point four kilometers the most complete circuit in England, walkable and free. The gates, or “bars,” did double duty as toll points, defenses and billboards of state terror: Micklegate Bar displayed the heads of traitors, including Richard, Duke of York in 1460 — crowned mockingly with paper — and rebels' heads remained a feature into the 1740s. Shakespeare has Queen Margaret order it: “Off with his head, and set it on York gates; so York may overlook the town of York.”

The Ninth Legion and the Working Fortress

Strip away the Vikings and the medieval walls and you reach York's foundation: a Roman legionary fortress, laid out on the high ground between two rivers in seventy-one, after the future emperor Petillius Cerialis pushed north. This was not a town but a military machine, home to a full legion, roughly five thousand professional soldiers, with the ordered geometry the Romans imposed everywhere, a rectangular circuit of walls, a grid of streets, headquarters, granaries, barracks, and a bathhouse whose remains you can peer at beneath a pub on Saint Sampson's Square, aptly named the Roman Bath. The corner of that fortress still stands ten courses high as the Multangular Tower in the Museum Gardens, its small Roman stones capped by larger medieval ones, a cross-section of the city in a single wall. The legion that built all this was the Ninth, Legio Nona Hispana, and it has become one of the great enigmas of Roman history. The Ninth garrisoned York, rebuilt its gates in stone, and then simply disappears from the record. The last firm evidence of the legion anywhere is an inscribed slab commemorating their reconstruction of a fortress gateway around one hundred and eight, now displayed in the Yorkshire Museum. After that, silence. By the middle of the second century the Ninth is gone from the army lists, and no later trace of it survives anywhere in the empire. The romantic explanation, immortalised in Rosemary Sutcliff's novel *The Eagle of the Ninth*, is that the legion marched into the mists of Caledonia and was annihilated by the northern tribes. Most modern historians are sceptical, and suspect a more mundane end, a transfer out of Britain, perhaps to the Rhine, and destruction years later in some lost war in the East, possibly the great Jewish revolt under Bar Kokhba or a campaign against Parthia. Either way, an entire legion vanished from history, which is a genuinely rare thing, and it happened to the very unit that gave York its first

walls. Their replacement was the Sixth Legion, Legio Sexta Victrix, which arrived around one hundred and twenty-two in the emperor Hadrian's baggage train and made Eboracum its home for the best part of three centuries. So the fortress outlived the men who built it, and the mystery of the Ninth remains York's oldest unsolved case, hiding under the pavements you are standing on.

Clifford's Tower and the Sabbath of 1190

The grassy mound crowned by a stone quatrefoil is Clifford's Tower, the keep of York Castle, and it is the setting of the darkest night in the city's history. The motte was thrown up for William the Conqueror around ten sixty-eight, one of two castles he planted to hold a city that kept rebelling; for its first century the keep on top was built of timber. In March eleven ninety, England was seized by crusading fever after the coronation of Richard the First, and a wave of anti-Jewish violence swept the country. York had a prosperous Jewish community, technically the personal property and responsibility of the king, and therefore both protected and resented. As the mob gathered, the community took refuge in the royal keep on this mound. The siege that followed was stoked by local gentry who owed the moneylenders substantial debts, chief among them Richard Malebisse, whose name conveniently translated as evil beast, a pun contemporaries did not miss. Trapped in the wooden tower on the night of the sixteenth of March, the eve of the great Sabbath before Passover, many of the besieged chose to take their own lives and those of their families rather than submit to forced baptism, setting the tower ablaze as they did. Those who surrendered the next morning on a promise of mercy were murdered anyway. Around one hundred and fifty people died, and the community was effectively extinguished. The killers then went to the Minster and burned the records of the debts they owed, which for some had been the point all along. The stone tower you see replaced the burned timber one: it was built for Henry the Third in the mid-thirteenth century in that distinctive four-lobed plan, and it takes the name Clifford probably from Roger de Clifford, hanged in chains from its walls in thirteen twenty-two. Its own end came in sixteen eighty-four, when an explosion, whether accident or arson, gutted the interior and left the roofless shell that survives. A memorial at the foot of the mound now marks the massacre, and the site has become a place of reflection as much as sightseeing. Climb it for the view over the rooftops to the Minster, by all means, but climb it knowing what happened here, because the prettiest cities often keep their hardest stories in their most photographed spots, and this is York's.

The Minster: Glass, Fire and the Long Build

York Minster is the largest medieval Gothic cathedral north of the Alps, built over roughly two hundred fifty years from 1220 as successive archbishops competed with Canterbury in stone. Its unmatched treasure is glass: the Minster holds around half of all the medieval stained glass surviving in England, an accident of the Civil War — the city's 1644 surrender was negotiated by Thomas Fairfax, a Yorkshireman who explicitly protected the churches from iconoclasm. The Great East Window, finished by 1408 by John Thornton of Coventry under a three-year contract with an on-time bonus, is the largest single expanse of medieval glazing in the world — a tennis court of glass narrating Creation to Apocalypse in over three hundred panels; its decade-long modern conservation, completed in 2018, was among the largest projects of its kind ever undertaken. The Five Sisters window in the north transept is older still — thirteenth-century grisaille, five lancets of silvery-grey geometry — and since 1925 has been the country's only memorial dedicated to women of the British Empire who died in the First World War. The building's afterlife has been eventful: an arsonist burned the choir in 1829; the central tower's foundations were found in the 1960s to be failing — the rescue excavation created the Undercroft, where you descend past Roman barracks and Norman foundations; and the 1984 south transept fire, days after a controversial bishop's consecration there, gave the restoration one charming touch — six of the new roof bosses were designed by children who won a television competition. Look up for a spacecraft among the medieval-style carvings.

The Chapter House, the Clock, and the Treasures

The glass gets the headlines, but the Minster rewards the visitor who explores its edges. Step into the Chapter House, the octagonal room off the north transept where the cathedral's governing canons once met. Completed in the twelve eighties, it performs a quiet feat of engineering: its wide vaulted ceiling has no central column. A stone vault of that span would have demanded a supporting pillar in the middle; instead the medieval carpenters built the roof in timber, cantilevered and balanced so that it holds itself, leaving the floor gloriously open. Around the walls runs some of the finest naturalistic thirteenth-century carving in England, canopies crowded with heads, foliage and grotesques, and a Latin inscription that boasts, with justification, that as the rose is the flower of flowers, so this is the house of houses. In the north transept, pause at the astronomical clock. It looks medieval but was installed in nineteen fifty-five, and it is a war memorial: its dials show the heavens as they would appear to an airman flying over York, commemorating roughly eighteen thousand aircrew from the bases of Yorkshire, Durham and Northumberland who died in the Second World War, their names recorded in a Book of Remembrance beneath it, a page turned each day. Then descend to the Undercroft treasury for the Horn of Ulf, an oliphant carved from a single elephant's tusk in Salerno, in southern Italy, in the early eleventh century. It is not merely decorative: the Anglo-Scandinavian magnate Ulf is said to have presented it to the church as the physical token conveying his estates, a drinking horn serving as a title deed in an age when a symbol placed in the hand outweighed any document. Finally, back in the nave, look high on the wall for the wooden dragon's head projecting into the space, painted and fierce, its original purpose long lost but most plausibly a medieval crane, a chain once running through the hole in its skull to raise and lower the heavy cover of the font below. None of these is the thing visitors come to see, which is precisely why they repay the detour: the self-supporting roof, the clock that maps a pilot's sky, the ivory horn that bought land, and the dragon that was really a machine. The Minster keeps its cleverest ideas in its corners.

Saint William, the Doomstone, and the Long Campaign

The Gothic Minster you walk through, begun in twelve twenty, is the latest great church on this spot, raised over a Norman cathedral that Archbishop Thomas of Bayeux began after the Conquest, which in

turn sat on the headquarters building of the Roman fortress. That layering is literal, and you can read it in the Undercroft. Down there, look for the Doomstone, a Norman carving from the twelfth century depicting the mouth of Hell as a great cauldron, demons shovelling the damned into it while toads and a money-bag-clutching miser illustrate the wages of greed. It is Romanesque terror at full volume, the medieval imagination's answer to a warning sign, and it survived precisely because it was buried and forgotten until the modern excavations uncovered it. The Minster also has its own saint, largely forgotten today, whose story is pure twelfth-century politics. William Fitzherbert was made Archbishop of York, then deposed amid accusations of bribery and unsuitability as reforming monks lobbied against him, then restored years later after his rivals faltered. He returned to York in triumph in eleven fifty-four, and within weeks was dead, taken violently ill after celebrating Mass, with poison in the chalice widely suspected and never proven. His enemies were accused; nothing was ever established. Miracles were soon reported at his tomb, he was canonised as Saint William of York in twelve twenty-six, and his shrine drew pilgrims and their offerings, the medieval equivalent of tourist revenue, helping to fund the very rebuilding you are admiring. A magnificent window in the choir, the Saint William Window, narrates his life and posthumous miracles across dozens of panels. Behind all of it lay a long rivalry with Canterbury over which archbishop held primacy in England, a competition fought partly in stone: York's canons wanted a cathedral that would not be outshone. That ambition is why the building took two and a half centuries to complete, why its glass and its towers are on the scale they are, and why a provincial northern city ended up with the largest Gothic cathedral in northern Europe. Faith, politics, a suspicious death and civic pride, all set in magnesian limestone, and most of it invisible unless you know to look for the buried mouth of Hell and the saint whose name the building has quietly kept.

The Shambles and the Snickelways: Medieval Streetscape as Survival

The Shambles — from “fleshammels,” the shelf-benches of butchers’ stalls — is routinely called Europe’s best-preserved medieval street, and its picturesqueness is entirely functional in origin. This was York’s dedicated butchery from at least the fourteenth century (Domesday Book already records butchers’ stalls here in 1086); the jettied upper floors that nearly touch overhead were built out to shade the meat displayed on the sill-boards below, and the raised pavements flanking a central channel managed the offal and blood. Some twenty-five butchers still traded here in the late nineteenth century; the last closed within living memory, and the hooks and sill-boards survive on several frontages. The street’s modern fame has a second layer: its resemblance to Diagon Alley — inspiration is claimed rather than confirmed by the filmmakers — has filled it with wizardry shops, an irony the tourist board has embraced without complaint. One sobering address: number 35 was the home of Margaret Clitherow, the butcher’s wife executed in 1586 for harboring Catholic priests — pressed to death under a door loaded with stones after refusing trial to protect her children from testifying — later canonized; a shrine on the street (probably not her actual house, scholarship suggests) marks her. Around the Shambles spreads the network of snickelways — the term coined only in 1983 by author Mark Jones, blending snicket, ginnel and alleyway — some fifty medieval shortcuts threading between streets. Lund’s Court, formerly Mad Alice Lane, and the passage grandly named Whip-Ma-Whop-Ma-Gate, York’s shortest street with its longest name, are the connoisseur’s picks.

Guy Fawkes and the Catholic Underground

York’s prettiest streets have a Catholic underground running beneath them, and its most infamous son was born a few steps from the Minster. Guy Fawkes came into the world in fifteen seventy in a house on Stonegate, and was baptised days later in Saint Michael le Belfrey, the church that stands cheek by jowl with the cathedral’s west front, its register still recording the entry. He was schooled in the city, at what is now Saint Peter’s School, alongside boys from families who would later turn recusant, that is, Catholics who refused to attend the state Protestant church and paid ruinous fines, or worse, for the refusal. Fawkes was born into a conventional Protestant household but converted to Catholicism as a young man, went abroad to fight for Catholic Spain in the Low Countries, where he acquired the military and gunpowder experience that made him useful, and adopted the name Guido. In sixteen hundred and five he became the hands-on man of the Gunpowder Plot, a conspiracy to blow up the House of Lords at the state opening of Parliament and, with it, King James the First, decapitating the Protestant establishment in a single blast. Thirty-six barrels of gunpowder were smuggled into a cellar beneath the chamber. An anonymous tip-off led to a search in the small hours of the fifth of November, and Fawkes was caught red-handed guarding the powder, giving a false name, ready to set it off. He was tortured, tried, and executed. The nation has burned his effigy every fifth of November since, which makes him the rare historical figure commemorated by a bonfire rather than a statue. His old school, with a nice sense of loyalty to a former pupil, is famously said to decline to burn a guy to this day. But the deeper York story is the one the souvenir shops leave out. This was a city where faith could be lethal, where families hid priests in concealed chambers, smuggled Mass vessels, and paid informers to look the other way, and Fawkes was simply its most spectacular product. The fudge counters and the wizard shops now sit on top of a century in which what you believed might cost you your house, your freedom, or your neck.

The Treasurer’s House and the Ghosts of a Haunted City

York markets itself, with some justification, as one of the most haunted cities in Europe, and if you want a single ghost story that has survived hard scrutiny, it is the one told in the Treasurer’s House, close by

the Minster. In nineteen fifty-three an eighteen-year-old apprentice named Harry Martindale was fitting pipework in the cellar when he heard a repeated note like a trumpet and then watched a Roman soldier emerge from the solid wall, followed by a carthorse and a straggling column of perhaps a dozen legionaries, dishevelled, weary, carrying round shields. The detail that has kept the story alive is this: he saw them only from the knees upward, as though they trod a surface below the modern floor. Martindale, badly shaken, recounted the tale consistently for the rest of his life and never took a penny for it. What lifts it above the ordinary is what the archaeology later showed. The Treasurer's House stands directly over the line of a Roman road, and the buried road surface lies at exactly the depth of the soldiers' hidden feet. More striking still, the round shields and scruffy appearance he described, initially dismissed as wrong for legionaries, actually fit the irregular troops garrisoning York in the later Roman period, details an untrained young plumber was unlikely to have invented. Sceptics reach for the well-documented tricks of memory and suggestion; believers point to a witness who never embellished and never profited. Either way it is a better story than most, because it is anchored in real stratigraphy. It also stands for something true about York as a whole: this is a city built in layers, where the past is quite literally underfoot, and the ghost walks that set out nightly from the Minster gates trade on a genuine sense that the dead are close to the surface here. You will pass the Golden Fleece, reputedly the city's most haunted pub, and a dozen guides in top hats promising highwaymen and grey ladies. Take the theatre for what it is. But the Treasurer's House tale endures because it fits the ground, and because a man told it the same way for fifty years and asked for nothing in return. In a city this old, the boundary between history and haunting is thinner than the tourist board even needs it to be.